
Santa Ana Regional Water Quality Control Board

December 30, 2025

Gilbert Hernandez
Public Works Director
City of Riverside
5950 Acorn Street
Riverside, CA 92504
GHernandez@riversideca.gov

NOTICE OF VIOLATION – UNAUTHORIZED DISCHARGES OF UNTREATED SEWAGE, CITY OF RIVERSIDE-RIVERSIDE REGIONAL WATER QUALITY CONTROL PLANT

Dear Mr. Hernandez:

On November 15 and 17, 2025, the City of Riverside-Department of Public Works (City or Discharger) experienced separate power outages, which resulted in separate discharges of untreated sewage. As a result of these unauthorized discharges of raw sewage, the Discharger violated prohibitions outlined in the Waste Discharge and Water Reclamation Requirements (WDRs) Order No. R8-2013-0016 and National Pollutant Discharge Elimination System (NPDES) Permit No. CA0105350 (the permit).

Specifically, on November 15, 2025, Santa Ana Water Board staff received an email notification from the City regarding a power outage due to an unknown cause resulting in the headworks overflowing. The overflow occurred at the Acorn/Arlanza influent station and traveled to an internal storm basin near the membrane bioreactor fine screens (see Attachment A). While the overflow of sewage was contained onsite, the duration of the spill was an hour. The Discharger pumped 706,410 gallons from the internal stormwater basin to headworks for further processing.

Subsequently, on November 18, 2025, Santa Ana Water Board staff received an email notification from the City regarding a power outage on November 17, 2025, caused by a vehicle hitting a power pole in the near vicinity resulting in the headworks overflowing. Standing water was identified inside the headworks building, the associated motor control room, and the area outside headworks caused by the sewage spill (see Attachment B). The total volume estimated of this spill was 11,912 gallons.

As a result of these unauthorized releases of raw sewage (untreated wastewater), the City has violated Discharge Prohibitions III.B of the permit. These violations are discussed in detail below:

Prohibition III.B of WDR Order No. R8-2013-0016 states,

"The discharge of wastewater at a location or in a manner different from those described in this Order is prohibited." The wastewater discharges (sewage overflows) cited in this letter occurred at the headworks, which is not an authorized discharge point under the Order, and therefore, the City has violated Prohibition III.B of the permit on two separate occasions.

The magnitude of these unauthorized releases of untreated wastewater and unknown circumstances that caused the unauthorized releases pose a major threat to receiving water quality. Therefore, as described in section X.B.5 of the permit, please submit a corrective action plan (CAP) detailing how the City's unauthorized release of untreated wastewater will be addressed by **March 31, 2026**. Although the City has provided details regarding the spill and the response actions taken, the City should include (but is not limited to) the following:

1. Provide additional details regarding the failure of the emergency backup generators¹.
2. Include a discussion on the unsafe conditions due to water entering the building where the generator connections are and the measures² being taken to prevent a recurrence.
3. Provide supporting calculations for the spill volumes, including volumes recovered.
4. Discuss any issues identified in troubleshooting and resolving these issues³.
5. Include corresponding implementation schedules for these items and all other corrective actions identified.

Please note that the City is required to also report the violations discussed in this letter in the cover letter for the self-monitoring report to be submitted for the period of November 2025 to the Santa Ana Water Board, as required under the permit, Attachment E, Monitoring and Reporting Program, Section X.B.5.

¹ The status of the last three tests was provided showing they were successful. However, a subsequent test on May 15th, 2025 was not. This unsuccessful test exposed additional issues with some generators. The Discharger stated they have been in communication with Carollo Engineering but have not shared how this was resolved or if there is an implementation schedule in place.

² The initial response to this item from the City (email dated November 24, 2025), stated the following measures would be considered: door elevation, drainage improvements, and providing relief points.

³ Responses to preliminary questions regarding the spills (email dated November 24, 2025) mentioned that the Discharger would be having multiple meetings with Carollo Engineering.

Please be advised that failure to provide the requested CAP by the assigned due date may lead to further enforcement action. We also request an in-person meeting with your team, to be scheduled for **January/February 2026**, to discuss the scope of your proposed corrective action.

Failure to comply with the permit or the Clean Water Act may result in the imposition of administrative civil liability. The Santa Ana Water Board may assess an administrative civil liability in an amount not to exceed \$10,000 for each day of violation plus \$10 for each gallon discharged and not cleaned up over 1,000 gallons. The Santa Ana Water Board may also refer this matter to the Attorney General's Office. Issuance of this Notice of Violation does not limit our ability to take additional enforcement measures for this or other violations at the Discharger's facilities.

If you have any questions regarding this letter, please contact me at (951) 782-7958 or at Nick.Amini@waterboards.ca.gov or Adriana Godinez at (951) 782-3286 or at Adriana.Godinez@waterboards.ca.gov.

Sincerely,



A. Nick Amini, Ph.D., P.E.

Branch Manager, Surface Water and Agriculture Branch

Enclosures: Attachment A – November 15, 2025 Spill
Attachment B – November 17, 2025 Spill

cc: City of Riverside-Robert Eland (Reland@riversideca.gov)
City of Riverside- Nicole Greenwood (NGreenwood@riversideca.gov)
City of Riverside- Estefania Solorio Sanchez (ESolorioSanchez@riversideca.gov)

CIWQS ID# 376054

ATTACHMENT A- NOVEMBER 15, 2025 SPILL



Figure 1. Acom/Arlanza Influent Station during the overflow on 11/15/25. Provided by the City in an email dated 11/17/25.



Figure 2. Map of Spill Flow Path. Provided by the City in an email dated 11/17/25.

ATTACHMENT B- NOVEMBER 17, 2025 SPILL



Figure 3. Inside the headworks building, associated motor control room, and area outside headworks that had standing water caused by the backup at headworks. Provided by the City in an email dated 11/18/25.